A Walk to Remember

By Nicholas Sparks

Now, Jamie was a nice girl. She really was, [but she] wasn't exactly what I considered attractive. Despite the fact that she was thin, with honey blond hair and soft blue eyes, most of the time she looked sort of . . . . plain. [And] Jamie carried her Bible wherever she went. She would [even] read the Bible during lunch break at school. Despite these strikes, though, the one thing that really drove me crazy about her was the fact that she was always so [dang] cheerful.

INTRODUCTION

In this heart-wrenching story, Landon Carter is shown the depths of the human heart and the joy and pain of living from a most unexpected person . . . Jamie Sullivan.

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The homecoming dance was coming up, and I still didn't have a date. So there I was, flipping through the

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pages in the [yearbook] when I saw Jamie Sullivan's picture. I closed the yearbook. Jamie Sullivan? [The reverend's] daughter? Absolutely not. I spent the rest of the evening debating the pros and cons, but in the end the choice was obvious. I had to ask Jamie to the dance. I made my way down the streets of Beaufort, reached her front door, took a second to catch my breath, and finally knocked.

JAMIE: Landon, this is a surprise! Well, I'd invite you in, but my father isn't home, and he doesn't allow boys in the house while he's not around.

LANDON: Oh, that's okay. We can talk out here, I guess.

JAMIE: So, what did you want to talk to me about?

LANDON: Sure is a beautiful day. Why I'll bet there's not a single cloud in the whole sky.

JAMIE: Landon, you didn't come here to talk about the weather, did you?

LANDON: Not really.

JAMIE: Then why are you here?

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LANDON: Well . . . . I wanted to know if you would like to go to the homecoming dance with me.

JAMIE: I'd love to . . . on one condition. You have to promise that you won't fall in love with me.

I knew she was kidding by the way she laughed, [so] I smiled and gave her my word. In the two weeks following the homecoming dance, my life pretty much returned to normal. Sunday I was in my room, working on my application to UNC. I was writing one of my essays when the phone rang.

JAMIE: Landon?

LANDON: Oh, hey. What's going on? Why are you calling me?

JAMIE: I wanted to ask you a favor. I'd like to ask you if you wouldn't mind playing Tom Thornton in the school play.

LANDON: Can't someone else do it instead?

Being seen with her once was bad enough . . . but being seen with her every day? What would my friends say? But I could tell this was really important to her.

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JAMIE: I've been praying about it, Landon. I'd really like this play to be special this year, not for me, but because of my father. I know how much it will mean to him to see me be the angel, because this play reminds him of my mother . . . Will you think about it?

The next day I talked to Miss Garber, went through the audition and got the part. Rehearsals started the next week. I began to stumble through my lines for the next few days, not really even attempting to learn them. I'd crack a joke or two, which everyone laughed at, except for Jamie and Miss Garber. [But] Jamie wasn't going to let me off that easy.

JAMIE: Do you ever think about the future, Landon? What you want to do with your life?

LANDON: I don't know yet. I haven't figured that part out. I'm going to UNC next fall, at least I hope so. I have to get accepted first. How about you? What do you want to do in the future?

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JAMIE: I want to get married. And when I do, I want my father to walk me down the aisle and I want everyone I know to be there. I want the church bursting with people. . . . Yes. That's all I want.

LANDON: Well, you'll get married someday. You'll meet some guy and the two of you will hit it off, and he'll ask you to marry him. And I'm sure that your father will be happy to walk you down the aisle.

JAMIE: *(wistfully)* I hope so.

The next night, as I was walking her home we talked about her Bible.

LANDON: Why do you always carry it with you?

JAMIE: It was my mother's.

LANDON: Oh . . . . I'm sorry I asked.

JAMIE: It's okay, Landon. How could you have known. My mother and father were given this Bible for their wedding, but my mom was the one who claimed it first. She read it all the time, especially whenever she was

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going through a hard time in her life. She had it with her in the hospital when I was born. When my father found out that she had died, he carried the Bible and me out of the hospital at the same time.

LANDON: I'm sorry.

JAMIE: It just gives me a way to . . . to be a part of her. Can you understand that?

The night of the play was cool and crisp. [My character] Tom Thornton is [is supposed to be] amazed when he first sees the angel [Jamie], which is why he goes around helping her as she shares Christmas with those less fortunate. The first words out of Tom's mouth are, "You're beautiful," and I was supposed to say them as if I meant them from the bottom of my heart. The problem, however, was that I still hadn't nailed this lie yet. Sure, I said the words, but they didn't come off to convincingly. I kept trying to imagine someone else as the angel so that I could get it just right. The next thing I knew, the curtain was opening and I was walking past storefronts and looking in windows for the music

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box my daughter wants for Christmas. My back was turned from where Jamie entered, but I heard the crowd collectively draw a breath as soon as she appeared on stage. I readied myself to turn around, and when I did, I finally saw what it was all about. Her honey-colored hair was handing loosely, with a trace of glitter in [it], sparkling like a crystal halo. It was absolutely amazing to behold. She was smiling slightly, as if she were holding a secret close to her heart. She looked exactly like an angel.

LANDON: You're . . . . You're beautiful

And I think that everyone in the whole auditorium knew that I actually meant it. To say that the play was a smashing success was to put it mildly. But because of Jamie's presence, it really became something special . . . . [After the play] Jamie insisted that I go with her to the orphanage on Christmas Eve.

JAMIE: I'm so glad you could come.

LANDON: So am I . . . . I bought you something . . . . A gift, I mean.

JAMIE: You didn't have to do that.

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LANDON: I know, but I wanted to.

JAMIE: I brought you something, too. Please, open it. I want you to have it.

I already knew what was inside, and I couldn't believe what she had done. My hands began to tremble. When it was finally free of the paper, I slowly ran my hand over the top of the well-worn leather as tears filled my eyes. Jamie had given me her Bible.

JAMIE: Thank you for doing what you did. It was the best Christmas I've ever had.

She smiled at me and I smiled at her and all I could do was wonder how I'd ever fallen in love with a girl like Jamie Sullivan. I drove Jamie home from the orphanage later that night.

JAMIE: Landon, do you ever think about God? Do you ever wonder why things have to turn out the way they do? I've been thinking about it a lot lately. I know the Lord has a plan for us all, but sometimes, I just don't understand what the message can be. Does that ever happen to you?

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LANDON: Well, I don't think that we're meant to understand it all the time. I think that sometimes we just have to have faith.

JAMIE: *(thoughtfully)* Yes, you're right.

I realized that Jamie had been misunderstood her entire life, not only by me, but by everyone. Jamie wasn't simply the minister's daughter, someone who read the Bible and did her best to help others. Jamie was also a 17-year-old girl with the same hopes and doubts that I had. At least that's what I assumed, until she finally told me.

JAMIE: People think I'm strange, don't they? Do you think I'm strange, too?

LANDON: You're a wonderful person, Jamie. You're beautiful, you're kind, you're gentle . . . you're everything that I'd like to be. I love you, Jamie. You're the best thing that ever happened to me.

JAMIE: *(beginning to cry)* Please don't say that. . . Please . . . . I'm sorry. I'm so, so sorry . . . You can't be in love with me, Landon We can

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be friends, we can see each other . . . but you can't love me.

LANDON: Why not?

JAMIE: Because, I'm very sick, Landon. I'm dying.

She had leukemia; she'd known it since last summer. Time had suddenly stopped and I understood everything. I understood why she'd wanted me to do the play; why she wanted Christmas to be so special. Why she'd given me her Bible.

LANDON: No, no, there has to be some mistake. Why didn't you tell me?

JAMIE: I'd made a decision that it would be better if I told no one, and I asked my father to do the same. No one would look me in the eye. If you had only a few months left to live, is that what you would want?

I was for the first time in my life, completely and utterly at a loss. I'd been in love with her for only 18 days. Those 18 days seemed like my entire life, but now, when I looked at her, all I could do was wonder how many more days there would be. On Monday she didn't

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show up for school, and I somehow knew that she'd never walk the hallways again. She was finished with school forever; she would never receive her diploma. I left school early and went to Jamie's

JAMIE: Hello, Landon, this is a surprise. My father isn't home right now, but if you'd like to sit on the porch, we can.

LANDON: How can you do this? How can you pretend that nothing is wrong? Aren't you frightened?

JAMIE: Yes, I'm frightened all the time. [But] when the doctors first told us, they said that I should try to lead as normal a life as possible for as long as I could.

LANDON: There's nothing normal about this.

JAMIE: I know. . . I know you're frightened too.

I began to pray for a miracle. We started reading the Bible together. On February 14, Valentines Day, Jamie picked out a passage that meant a lot to her. She told me that if she'd ever had the chance, it was the passage she'd wanted read at her wedding.

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JAMIE: Love is always patient and kind. It is never jealous. Love is never boastful or conceited. It is never rude or selfish. It does not take offense and is not resentful. Love takes no pleasure in other people's sins, buts delights in the truth. It is always ready to excuse, to trust, to hope and to endure whatever comes.

Jamie was the truest essence of that very description. A week later Jamie's trips to the hospital became more regular, although she insisted that she didn't want to stay there overnight.

JAMIE: I want to die at home.

Since the doctors couldn't do anything for her, they had no choice but to accept her wishes

LANDON: I've been thinking about the past few months. Do you have any regrets?

JAMIE: We all have regrets, Landon. But I've led a wonderful life.

LANDON: How can you say that? With all that's happening to you.

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JAMIE: I've been happy, Landon. I really have. I've had a special father who taught me about God. I can look back and know that I couldn't have tried to help other people any more than I did. I've even fallen in love and had someone love me back.

LANDON: Will you do something for me?

JAMIE: I don't know if I can anymore.

LANDON: Will you marry me?

Just as she'd wanted, the church was bursting with people as we were married on March 12, 1959. Although Jamie was weak and hadn't moved from her bed in two weeks, she insisted on walking down the aisle so that her father could give her away.

JAMIE: It's very important to me, Landon. It's part of my dream, remember?

Then Jamie and [her dad] slowly made their way down the aisle, while everyone in the church sat silently in wonder. Halfway down the aisle, Jamie suddenly seemed to tire, and they stopped while she caught her breath. Her eyes closed, and I remember thinking it

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was the most difficult walk anyone ever had to make. In every way, a walk to remember.

It was, I remember, the most wonderful moment of my life. In front of God and everyone else, I'd promised my love and devotion, in sickness and in health, and I'd never felt so good about anything. It is now forty years later, and I can still remember everything from that day. I still love her, you see, and I've never removed my ring. I smile slightly, looking toward the sky, knowing there's one thing I still haven't told you: I now believe that miracles can happen.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nicholas Sparks
ISBN: 978-0446693806
Publisher: Grand Central Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2004

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